

THE GIANT STEPS

- India needs to introduce a credible accreditation system to authentically evaluate higher education institutions
- Increasing and improving student access to quality education is crucial. A top-notch online education model that has been designed for India and works at scale is the answer
- Entrance tests and coaching centres stop learners from developing their creativity or their critical thinking skills
- To improve the lot of students, India needs to reduce its dependence on entrance examinations for all disciplines

student support services. They develop a competitive spirit that, in turn, can lead to a much-improved higher education environment across India. Three, improving the overall quality of our universities enhances their global standing and makes them more attractive to international students and faculty.

We also urgently need to increase and improve student access to quality education. A large number of young people in our country need to be educated. But the old model of building more classrooms and finding more teachers to teach more students doesn't work. Stated GER (gross enrolment ratio) targets will require India to double the number of universities and colleges in the next 10 years. It is physically impossible to build that many campuses or find those many talented teachers.

World's best digital university: Therefore, we must rely on technology to increase access. So far, digital delivery is a low-quality replication of the offline model. Swayam, the government portal, offers free educational courses, but only four per cent of students who enrol in its courses are reported to successfully complete them. What India needs is a top-notch online education model that has been designed for India and works at scale. We have not just the opportunity but also the talent to build the world's best digital university. The government had talked about such a university while presenting the Union budget in 2022. It's an idea whose time has come.

My last point is linked to improving the lot and life of our students. While I don't have a silver-bullet solution to offer, we definitely need to reduce our dependence on entrance examinations for everything, from engineering to medicine to law to humanities. These exams may have been started with the best of intentions, but the high stakes have ended up causing stress and anxiety and forcing students into rote learning.

We are essentially equating education with entrance examinations and, in the process, damaging generations of young people. Because all they are doing is sweating in coaching classes for tests that they see as a pathway to a high-quality institution and, eventually, the career of their dreams.

The pressure doesn't ease when students get into college, because then they start preparing for CAT or other post-graduate entrance exams. Entrance tests are creating massive distortions as learners are not getting to experience, leave alone enjoy, the full school and college experience. They have no time to develop creativity or critical thinking skills; they're too busy cramming. We need to rejig this system before it's too late.

More can be done to improve our educational system. But by implementing the changes mentioned here, India can make a start on elevating its higher education system and ensuring that its institutions produce graduates who are well-prepared for the demands of the modern world. Only then can we become a global hub for higher education. ■

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